

DIVISION III

Allen is Regina's engineer

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The last thing that concerns Regina's Keesha Allen are the points she scores each night.

Sure, like any player, she enjoys seeing her name in a box score or a game summary.

However, as the starting point guard for one of the premier Division III teams in the state and one of the top girls basketball programs in the country, the savvy senior understands her role and the effect it can have on the Royals' success.

"As we enter the sectional tournament on Feb. 21, we are aware that we need to look to Keesha as our catalyst," said Pat Diulus, Regina coach and athletic director. "A pure point guard that has always put the team's goals in front of her own, she is the engine that will take the Regina train through the month of March."

If you don't follow Regina basketball and happen to look at the box scores of the Royals' last two games, you might think the engine is slowing.

Allen scored four points in each of the victories, which included the domina-

tion of Lake Erie League power Elyria. But, it's what didn't show up in those box scores that has earned Allen a scholarship to the University of Cincinnati.

"She had eight steals and eight assists in each game," Diulus said. "She does it all."

Any coach will tell you that a player's value can be determined by the recruiting process. The amount and quality of interested schools is dictated by that player's skills. Allen, a four-year varsity mainstay, was recruited by several national programs before she decided on Cincinnati.

Regina, which entered this week with a 17-1 record and a second-place ranking in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 poll, has a wealth of talent. And it's Allen's job to see that the Royals spread the wealth on the floor.

Allen, who joins teammates G Ann Lauder (James Madison) and Colleen Tootz (Niagara) as major-college signees, possesses a stat that places her among the best point guards Diulus has coached — an assist-to-turnover ratio of 4-1.

PLAIN DEALER
Keesha Allen

Pymatuning Valley Sectional-District
Where: Pymatuning Valley High, Andover. Call (440) 293-6263.
Who: Ashtabula Harbor, Badger, Berkshire, Brookfield, Cardinia, Grand Valley, Harvey, Hawken, Maplewood, Pymatuning Valley, Villa Angela-St. Joseph, Warren Champion and Wickliffe.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6 and 7-30 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 2 p.m. Winner advances to Alliance regional March 8 and 11.

Favorites: Villa Angela-St. Joseph.

Darshores: Hawken and Berkshire.

What to watch: VASA lacks the quickness that sparked it to the state championship last season. The Vikings remain a balanced team, though, and have tournament-tested veterans such as Megan Flynt and Amanda Avram.

Hawken has an interesting mix of size and quickness. Hawks guard Jasmine Rowan is a premier 3-point shooter who can go strong to the basket, too.

The X Factor: Megan Pavli, Berkshire.

The Badgers play a deliberate half-court offense, but Pavli and pals create havoc with their scrambling defense. If the Badgers can get the offense in the offense — and thus ignite their transition game — look out.

Rootstown Sectional-District

Where: Rootstown High, 4190 SR 44, Rootstown. Call (330) 325-7911.

Who: Beavercreek, Chagrin Falls, Cleveland Central Catholic, Cuyahoga Valley Christian, Garrettsville Garfield, Hathaway Brown, Warren John F.

Kennedy, Laurel, Regina, Rootstown, Streetsboro, Waterloo and Woodridge.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6 and 7-30 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 2 p.m. Winner advances to Alliance regional March 8 and 11.

Favorites: Top-seeded Regina.

Darshores: Woodridge (16-3).

What to watch: Keep your eye on Regina, regional finalist last season, which has lost once this season. The Royals are deep and talented, and just about everyone can score. Second-seeded Woodridge won its first Portage County League championship in 20 years. The Bulldogs will rely on Rachel Kaser and Heather Hammond, who scored 21 and 15 points, respectively, as Woodridge won its crown with a 55-51 victory over Southeast.

The X Factor: Regina's G Ann Lauder.

She averages 13.2 points and 13.1 rebounds and will cause opponents trouble in the paint.

Smithville Sectional-District

Where: Wilbur Berkey Gymnasium,

Smithville High, 480 E. Main St., Smithville. Call (330) 669-3165.

Who: Chippewa, Fairless, Hillsdale, Loudonville, Manchester, Norwytown, Northwestern, Our Lady of the Elms, Rittman, St. Vincent-St. Mary, Smithville, Tuslaw and Waynesdale.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6:15 and 8 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 2 p.m. Winner advances to the Mount Union regional March 8 and 11.

Favorites: Top-seeded Manchester and second-seeded Chippewa.

Darshores: Smithville.

What to watch: It's always nice to play on your home floor, especially when you have a decent team, and Smithville is decent. Manchester is 71-12 the last four seasons but has failed to advance any deeper than the district finals.

Manchester guard Erika Eckert has made an official visit to Mount Union College, but you can bet she would love to make another as a regional qualifier.

The Panthers have only themselves to fear.

The X Factor: Manchester's Nicole Neila.

Another in a class of outstanding sophomores in the area, she seems to improve with each outing. At 6-2, she is the central figure in the Lady Panthers' pound-it-inside offense, and in the last nine games, she has raised her scoring average from a little more than six points a game to its present 13.5.

Wellington Sectional-District

Where: Wellington High, 629 N. Main St., Wellington. Call (440) 647-3734.

Who: Avon, Black River, Brooklyn, Clearview, Columbia, Elyria Catholic, Firelands, Keystone, Lutheran West, Mapleton, Oberlin, St. Augustine and Wellington.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6 and 8 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 1 p.m. Winner advances to Lexington regional March 8 and 11.

Favorites: Clearview.

Darshores: Seeded teams Keystone (1), Brooklyn (2), Avon (3) and Lutheran West (4).

What to watch: Clearview, the two-time defending district champion, wasn't represented at the seeding meeting.

With the first three seeds receiving first-round byes, Clearview, with the ninth pick, drew the honor of meeting fourth-seeded Lutheran West in the opener. This game could be a pay-back notice for the rest of the field.

The X Factor: Clearview's 5-senior Kerri Tolva. She averages 15 points and was a starter the last two seasons. Can score and pass to her teammates, making her a double threat.

HIGH SCHOOLS

Bulldogs take fifth straight SWC title

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The Olmsted Falls Bulldogs have tasted victory before.

But, for a group of kids who have battled back all season, last night's triumph was especially sweet.

The Bulldogs, coming on strong in the final five minutes, turned back Avon Lake, 68-58, in the Southwestern Conference boys basketball headliner in Olmsted Falls.

With the victory, the Bulldogs improved to 16-2, 12-1 in the conference, and wrapped up their fifth consecutive SWC title.

"They're all great," said Olmsted Falls veteran coach Pat Donahue. "But what makes this one so special was the adversity these kids had to overcome."

OLMSTED FALLS
AVON LAKE68
58

The Bulldogs, who have encountered injuries all season, including the loss of standout senior point guard Larry Mucha to a separated shoulder, did again last night what they've been doing the last month — finding a way.

Avon Lake, which defeated Olmsted Falls in their first meeting at Avon Lake, turned to the strong inside play of 6-6 senior center Paul Skellenger and the long-range shooting of junior guard Brian Ingelright and held a 30-28 lead at halftime after Skellenger scored on a breakaway dunk. Skellenger and Ingelright each scored 12 points in the first half, offsetting the 15 points put up in the first 16 minutes by Bulldogs All-Ohio junior forward Mike Gansey.

The Shoremen, who slipped to 13-4, 9-4, pushed their lead to 34-29 on a driving layup by Skellenger with 6:27 remaining in the third quarter.

But Olmsted Falls regrouped and tied the score on a 3-pointer by senior guard Greg Koch and a jumper from the top of the key by senior forward Jeremy Holland.

A layup by senior guard Manzie Williams off a steal and an assist by Koch, two free throws by Koch and a reverse layup along the baseline by Gansey gave the Bulldogs a 44-38 lead with 2:39 left in the third quarter.

"They did a real nice job against our pressure at their place," Donahue said. "So tonight, we just tried to mix things up defensively."

Trailing, 46-42, entering the fourth quarter, Avon Lake closed to 48-47 on a 3-pointer by senior

guard Tim Guenther. But Olmsted Falls responded with two more free throws by Koch and then came the stretch that Shoremen coach Dave Olinger described as crucial.

The Bulldogs, hustling after loose balls and offensive rebounds, increased their advantage to 58-51 on a 3-pointer by senior guard Andy Jaroscak with 2:25 remaining. Avon Lake cut the deficit to 58-53 on a layup by Skellenger, who finished with a game-high 24 points.

But Olmsted Falls had the answer again in the form of a spinning one-hander high off the glass by Gansey and four straight free throws — two each by Koch and Williams. Gansey and Koch led the Bulldogs with 22 and 20 points, respectively.

Email: edwyer@pland.com
Phone: (216) 999-4677

Righting their course

Falcons get lost but teach Skippers lesson on the court

By TIM WARSINSKEY
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

In a farflung league where a strong understanding of Northeast Ohio geography is a must, Lutheran East apparently is a little behind on its homework.

But the Falcons aced their exam last night.

After a late arrival in Fairport Harbor — the Falcons got lost — Lutheran East successfully navigated its way to an important boys basketball victory over the Skippers, 86-69.

Lutheran East (13-1, 12-2) entered last night tied for first place in the East Suburban Conference with Southington. Fairport (13-6, 11-4) saw its chances for the league title dim with a loss to Southington last week, and the lights went out last night.

BOYS BASKETBALL

way to an important boys basketball victory over the Skippers, 86-69.

Lutheran East (13-1, 12-2) entered last night tied for first place in the East Suburban Conference with Southington. Fairport (13-6, 11-4) saw its chances for the league title dim with a loss to Southington last week, and the lights went out last night.

LUTHERAN EAST FAIRPORT

86
69

The Skippers might have suffered additional losses in the fourth quarter when point guard Danny Anderson crumbled under the boards with an ankle injury and forward Dave Socha aggravated a hand injury.

Lutheran East, which is unseeded at the Strongsville Division IV sectional-district tournament, closes league play against dangerous Maplewood tomorrow and Sis John & Paul on Friday.

Despite toiling in an off-off-Broadway league, the young Falcons have earned enough recognition to earn their first spot 25th — in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 yesterday. They backed it up with an impressive performance against the Skippers, who tried to run with Lutheran East but couldn't keep up.

"Our quickness and our mental toughness were the difference," Lutheran East coach Paul Wordell said. "These guys have grown up since the turn of the millennium."

"A lot of them are juniors and didn't have the varsity experience. They had to feel their way through on the varsity level and learn the little things."

Four of the Falcons' five starting juniors were in double figures — Carlton Dean (21 points), DeLonte Fomby (19), Allen Kirkpatrick (14) and Chuck Patton (10). Patton also was a disruptive force on defense, and the fifth starter, junior center Antonio Nettles,



CHITTY COPLAND/PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Fairport's Bryan Haight is fouled by Karl Lloyd during Lutheran East's 86-69 victory.

had eight points and eight rebounds.

Before last night, Fairport coach Tim Starkey said the Falcons could be the best team in the ESC when they are on their game. They had several such stretches against the Skippers, the most vital coming in the fourth quarter, when they stopped a Fairport rally and stretched a nine-point lead to 17 points with a 10-2 run.

That also was when Anderson and Socha went down.

The initial separation occurred in the first half. After Fairport took a 13-10 lead late in the first quarter, Lutheran East scored the next 11 points for a 21-13 lead early in the second quarter.

The Skippers cut the margin to five points, but the Falcons surged to a 45-35 lead at the half. They never led by less than nine in the second half.

As the Skippers fell behind, their play became more ragged and Lutheran East paraded to the free-throw line to make 22 of 33 foul shots.

"I lost my cool a little bit, and the players kind of lost control," Starkey said. "We gambled and made some mistakes, and they took advantage of everything."

Fairport had won seven in a row until losing to Southington and Lutheran East.

Email: twarsinskey@pland.com
Phone: 1-800-275-5253

Stockman tops mark as Medina triumphs

SOUTHEAST REPORT

Medina guard Tony Stockman scored 30 points and became the leading scorer in school history as the Bees rolled past Westlake, 65-46, in boys basketball last night.

Stockman, a 6-1 point guard headed for Cleveland, has 1,022 points. The former record of 1,020 was held by Ryan Sooy.

Stockman's record-breaking basket — a 5-foot jumper in the lane — came in the fourth quarter. Stockman also had seven assists for the Bees (15-2).

Central-Hower 73, Akron Garfield 68 — Brandon Greene scored 20 points to lead the Eagles to victory in an Akron City Series semifinal.

Andre Stone and Lamont Jones each scored 13 as Central-Hower advanced to the championship game. Andre Vaughn scored 21 points for Garfield (9-9).

Central-Hower will meet Buchtel for the championship Friday at 6:30 p.m. at Firestone High. Buchtel defeated Akron East, 84-49, in the other semifinal.

Buchtel has won the last four conference tournaments.

Southeast 87, Rootstown 84 — The Pirates trailed, 58-30, with five minutes left in the third quarter of this Portage County League game.

Jim Seaman paced Southeast's comeback, scoring 32 of his 36 points in the second half.

Mike Dillon scored 34 points for Rootstown. Dillon and Seaman are tied for the league's top scoring average.

Southeast improved to 9-8, 6-6 in the league. Rootstown dropped to 6-11, 5-7.

GIRLS BASKETBALL

Jefferson 74, Riverside 65 — Kelly Kopperer scored 33 points, 22 in the second half. The Falcons trailed, 19-17, after one quarter but rallied to take a 36-30 halftime lead.

Heidi Galm scored 24 points for the Beavers, 17 in the second half. Jefferson improved to 17-3; Riverside fell to 8-11.

Riverside coach Eric Seuffer said he was proud of his team even though it lost.

"We were aggressive, and we weren't intimidated," he said. "We came out with confidence."

HOCKEY

Euclid 9, Benedictine 1 — Christopher Gates scored three goals and Joshua Nagle had two as the Panthers knocked off the Bengals in sectional tournament action.

Nagle also had two assists. Brad Kitchen and Edward Ostrander each had three assists.

Rocky River 6, Elyria Catholic 3 — The score was tied at 1 after the first period. Then, the Pirates erupted for three goals within two minutes of the second period, giving them a 4-1 lead entering the third period.

DIVISION IV



PLAIN DEALER

Fairport's Jessica Hibbard will be a handful for opponents in the tournament. The 6-foot center averages 18 rebounds and 15 points a game.

Richmond Heights Sectional-District

Where: Richmond Heights High, 447 Richmond Rd., Richmond Heights. Call (216) 692-4097.

Who: Chanel, Fairport Harbor Harding, Gilmour, Kirtland, Ledgemont, Lutheran East, Newbury, Orange Christian, Richmond Heights, St. John & Paul and Windham.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6:15 and 8 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 2 p.m. Winner advances to Massillon regional.

Favorites: Chanel.

Darshores: Windham, Kirtland, Fairport.

What to watch: Chanel, ranked seventh in the state, clearly is the best team, with several others one step behind. The Firebirds feature guards Rachel Moore, Tana Richey and Amber Gooden. Third-seeded Kirtland won the tourney as the fourth seed last year.

The X Factor: Kirtland's top post players. Monica Gerlosky and Megan Creveling could offer guard-oriented Chanel some problems in a potential sectional. Gerlosky averages 17 points and 8.5 rebounds, and Creveling averages 12 points and 10 rebounds.

Norwayne Sectional-District

Where: Norwayne High, 350 S. Main St., Creston. Call (330) 435-6704.

Who: Cuyahoga Heights, Dalton, East Canton, First Baptist Christian, Independence, Kidron Central Christian, Lake Ridge, Lorain Catholic, Mogadore and Open Door Christian.

When: Semifinals — March 2, 6 and 8 p.m.; Finals — March 4, 2 p.m. Winner advances to the Massillon Perry regional March 9 and 11.

Favorites: Independence and Kidron Central Christian.

Darshores: Lorain Catholic and unseeded Mogadore.

What to watch: Top-seeded Independence shared the MAC-8 title with a talented Brooklyn team. In 5-10 senior Margie Kall and 5-11 freshman Jessie Crooks, the Lady Devils have size and athleticism in the post. Crooks, sister of former Independence basketball and baseball standout Jim Crooks, averages 9.2 rebounds. Speaking of talent in the frontcourt,

Lorain Catholic has a capable 1-2 punch in senior center Amanda Berry and junior forward Quinn Szenté. Berry averages 18.8 points, and Szenté pulls down 9.6 rebounds per game.

The X Factor: Tiffany Smejkal, Independence. Last year's MVP of the MAC-8, Smejkal has the ability to take over a game on offense. While she hasn't put up the same numbers this season, the 5-9 senior forward showed what she is capable of when she tied her school record with 30 points in a 56-50 loss at Brooklyn on Feb. 8.

Melanie Kozlowski

School: Holy Name
Sport: Basketball Class: Senior
Age: 17 Ht: 6-0 Wt: 145

Last week: Helped Green Wave to third consecutive North Coast League title by totaling 36 points, 15 rebounds, 12 steals and nine assists in victories over Lake Catholic and Notre Dame-Cathedral Latin; hit four 3-pointers and was 10-of-11 from free-throw line.

Season: Miami University recruit averages 18 points.

Personal: Member of National Honor Society, Spanish Club and student council; wishes to thank family, teammates and coaches for their support; enjoys watching "Dawson's Creek," "ER," "Who Wants To Be A Millionaire" and "Seventh Heaven."



Johanna Green

School: Cleveland Cent. Catholic
Sport: Basketball Class: Junior
Age: 16 Ht: 5-7 Wt: 126

Last week: Led North Coast League victories over Trinity and state-ranked St. Peter Chanel by totaling 46 points, 13 rebounds, nine assists and eight steals; scored 25 points in 64-55 upset of Chanel.

Season: Averages 13.1 points, 5.1 rebounds, 4.8 assists and 3.3 steals.

Personal: Also competes in track; member of honor roll; enjoys watching "Popular," favorite athletes are teammates Rachawn Terry and Cena Rose; favorite team is Cleveland Rockers.